2026-11-10
Memorial

St. Leo the Great

Pope and Doctor of the Church · Feast, Nov 10



The Meeting of Leo the Great and Attila, Raphael and workshop, 1513–14, Stanza di Eliodoro, Vatican[1]

1. Raphael and workshop, *The Meeting of Leo the Great and Attila*, fresco, 1513–14, Stanza di Eliodoro, Apostolic Palace, Vatican; Wikimedia Commons.

✠ The Essentials

- **Origin:** a native of Tuscany, the son of a man named Quintianus.[2]
- **Born:** the place and date of his birth are unknown.[3]
- **Died:** November 10, 461, at Rome. He was buried in the vestibule of St. Peter's on the Vatican.[4]
- **Feast:** November 10 on the Church's calendar today. The Catholic Encyclopedia, written in 1910, gives April 11 for the Latin Church of that time.[5] [6]
- **Titles:** Pope (440–461) and Doctor of the Church, a title Benedict XIV gave him in 1754.[7] [8]

✠ His Life in Brief

Leo is first known as a deacon of the Roman Church under Pope Celestine I.[9] When Pope Sixtus III died in 440, Leo was away in Gaul on an errand for the emperor, and the Romans chose him to succeed.[10] He was consecrated on September 29, 440, and governed the Roman Church for twenty-one years.[11]

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2. "Pope St. Leo I (the Great)," in *The Catholic Encyclopedia*, vol. 9 (New York: Robert Appleton Company, 1910).
3. Ibid.
4. Ibid.
5. *The Roman Missal*, Memorial of St. Leo the Great (November 10); *Liturgy of the Hours*, same day.
6. "Pope St. Leo I," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
7. Ibid.
8. Ibid.
9. Ibid.
10. Ibid.
11. Ibid.

- His chief aim was to keep the unity of the Church. He ordered Pelagian clerics in Aquileia to renounce their heresy publicly, and in Rome in 443 he led an investigation of a hidden Manichaean community.[12] [13]
- In 449 he sent a dogmatic letter on the Incarnation to Flavian of Constantinople, now called the *Tome*. The Council of Chalcedon in 451 solemnly accepted it as an expression of the Catholic faith about the Person of Christ.[14] [15]
- In 452 he went to meet Attila, King of the Huns, at Mincio near Mantua and obtained his promise to withdraw from Italy.[16]
- In 455, when the Vandals took Rome, his intercession won a promise that the city would not be burned and that lives would be spared, though the plundering lasted a fortnight.[17]
- Ninety-six of his sermons survive, and they are remarkable for their depth, clear speech and lofty style.[18]

✠ Famous Excerpt: *Sermon* 21 (Christmas)

> *"Christian, acknowledge your dignity, and becoming a partner in the Divine nature, refuse to return to the old baseness by degenerate conduct. Remember the Head and the Body of which you are a member."*[19]

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12. Ibid.
13. Ibid.
14. Ibid.
15. Ibid.
16. Ibid.
17. Ibid.
18. Ibid.
19. Leo the Great, *Sermon* 21, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, vol. 12, trans. Charles Lett Feltoe (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1895).

✠ 1. Catechesis

Lesson: Who Jesus is, in the words of the Creed. Leo told Flavian that the Creed itself answers the error about Christ. Everyone who is to be born again confesses faith in God the Father Almighty and in Jesus Christ, his only Son, our Lord, born of the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary.[20] At Christmas he taught the people the same thing: "unless He were true God, He would not bring us a remedy, unless He were true Man, He would not give us an example."[21]

Exercise: have students list what Jesus does for us as God (the remedy) and what he shows us as man (the example).

✠ 2. Apologetics

Objection 1: "Christ only seemed to be a man." Eutyches held something close to this, and Leo answered that although the Holy Spirit gave the Virgin fertility, "a real body was received from her body."[22] He also pointed to the Gospels, to Paul, and to the prophets as proof that Christ was of the seed of David and Abraham.[23]

Objection 2: "Papal primacy was a later invention." The record in Leo's own time shows the primacy at work in several places. He overruled Bishop Hilary of Arles in a dispute about jurisdiction, and the emperor Valentinian III issued an edict in 445 that recognized the primacy of the Bishop of Rome over the whole Church.[24] The Catholic Encyclopedia notes that Leo's first five sermons, given

20. Leo the Great, Letter 28 (the *Tome*) to Flavian, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, vol. 12, trans. Charles Lett Feltoe (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1895).
21. Leo, *Sermon* 21.
22. Leo, *Tome*.
23. Ibid.
24. "Pope St. Leo I," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.

on the anniversaries of his consecration, show his firm conviction of that primacy.[25]

✠ 3. Theology

- **One Person, two natures:** "Without detriment therefore to the properties of either nature and substance which then came together in one person, majesty took on humility, strength weakness, eternity mortality."[26]
- **The Mediator:** true God and true man were combined to form one Lord, so that the one Mediator "could both die with the one and rise again with the other."[27]
- **Our dignity:** because we are baptized into Christ, we share in the Divine nature and must not return to the old baseness.[28]

✠ 4. Devotional Prayer

Collect, Memorial of St. Leo the Great (Roman Missal, November 10):[29]

O God, who never allow the gates of hell to prevail against your Church, firmly founded on the apostolic rock, grant her, we pray, that through the intercession of Pope Saint Leo, she may stand firm in your truth and know the protection of lasting peace.

Practice: Say the Apostles' Creed slowly today, pausing on "born of the Virgin Mary," and give thanks that Christ is truly God and truly man.

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25. Ibid.
26. Leo, *Tome*.
27. Leo, *Sermon* 21.
28. Ibid.
29. *The Roman Missal*, 3rd typical ed. (2011), November 10, Memorial of St. Leo the Great, Collect.

✠ Today's Takeaway

Leo taught that Christ is both true God and true man, and he reminded every Christian to live up to the dignity of that gift.[30]

St. Leo the Great, pray for us.

30. Leo, *Sermon* 21.